Mixing or Moving? Segregation, Gentrification and the Renewal of the Waterloo Estate

Contents

1. Introduction
2. The global city: why Waterloo is drawn into the dispute
3. Housing: the strategy, and the conflict between home and real estate
4. Segregation: testing the remedy against the chain
5. Gentrification: price, cost and promise
6. Conclusion and discussion

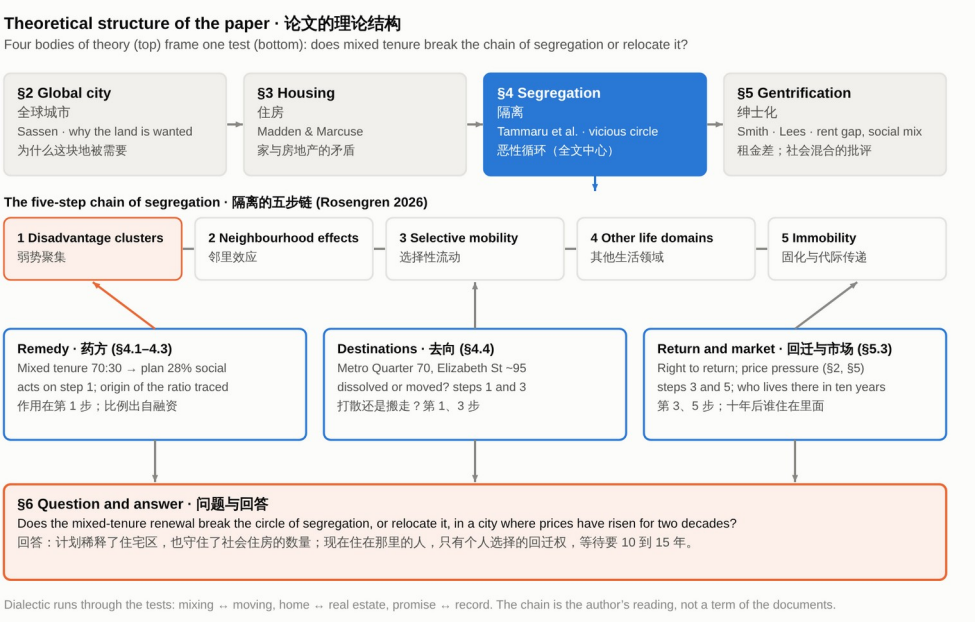


Figure 0. Theoretical structure: four bodies of theory frame one test of the chain of segregation.

1. Introduction

Mixing tenures is a standard remedy for the concentration of disadvantage in public housing estates. The NSW Government justified renewing its estates with a diagnosis, that disadvantage clusters in estates and is "passed on through multiple generations" (NSW Government 2016, PDF p. 24), and with a remedy, a 70:30 split between private and social dwellings "to enable more integrated communities" (NSW Government 2016, PDF p. 9). This paper asks whether the renewal of the Waterloo estate in Sydney breaks that circle of segregation or only moves it. It reads the renewal as state-led gentrification of a public housing estate and asks, for each of Marcuse's four forms of displacement, what evidence from 2019 to 2026 exists at Waterloo South. The evidence is strongest for protection against exclusion, since the number of social homes rises, and weakest for the people who live there now: return is an individual choice for existing tenants, and it cannot yet be observed.

Waterloo, with about 2,000 dwellings on 18 hectares, is among Sydney's largest inner-city public housing estates (Chatterjee et al. 2018), and its renewal has been described as the largest estate renewal proposed in Australia to date (Zanardo et al. 2024, 1208).

The renewal takes place in an expensive market: the median price of attached dwellings in Sydney more than doubled between 2006 and 2026 (Australian Bureau of Statistics 2026), and the sale of private dwellings funds the renewal (Zanardo et al. 2024, 1208).

Existing work on Waterloo concerns reputation and displacement. Zanardo et al. (2024, 1236) and Sisson (2024) describe a reputational gap, a term Yrjänä (2026) attributes to Kallin, in which the present of a place is devalued and its imagined potential is set against it, and Wynne and Rogers (2021) show how residents experience the threat of displacement before any demolition. This paper takes reputation as background and reads the plan as gentrification, against the five steps of the vicious circle of segregation and the four forms of displacement.

The paper is a document analysis. Its materials are the planning documents for Waterloo South (the plan finalisation report, the final planning proposal and the Design Guide, all from 2022) and for the concept application of 2025–26 (the proponent's scoping report, the issued assessment requirements, the exhibition notice and appendices A–E of the impact statement), government statements and media releases from 2015 to 2026, news reports, the 2020 social baseline report and census figures for Waterloo, and published studies of Waterloo and of estates elsewhere in Australia and the United States. Each protection for tenants is sorted by where it appears: in a binding planning control, in the Design Guide, in a statement inside the planning record, or only in an announcement.

The argument has three steps. First, the estate is a pocket of low-income, older and lone-person households inside an area the market has already mixed, and Sydney's concentrations of disadvantage lie elsewhere (section 4). Second, the renewal is state-led, new-build gentrification, and Marcuse's four forms of displacement give a way to sort what is known (section 5). Third, the evidence from 2019 to 2026 is collected for each form (Table 2), and it protects the number of social homes better than it protects the people (section 6). The sections take four bodies of urban theory in turn: the global city, housing, segregation and gentrification.

2. The global city: why Waterloo is drawn into the dispute

The strategy that frames Sydney as a global city does not name Waterloo. The state's 2014 metropolitan strategy defines a Global Economic Corridor that "generates over 41 per cent of the NSW Gross State Product" and lists Green Square among its strategic centres, in line with the global-city idea that a city's competitiveness rests on central land, infrastructure and the services of a global economy (Sassen 1991; NSW Planning and Environment 2014, 44).

The renewal is paid for by selling new private flats, and the price of those flats has risen strongly. The median transfer price of attached dwellings in Sydney rose from $390,000 in June 2006 to $840,000 in June 2026 (Australian Bureau of Statistics 2026; Figure 1).



Figure 1. Sydney's median transfer prices rose strongly between 2006 and 2026.

What brought the pressure to Waterloo was a metro station, which the urban design study calls "the catalyst for the renewal" (Turner Studio & Turf 2020, Part 1, PDF p. 6). The reason given for replacing the housing is a different one, a statewide diagnosis that "many estates experience high levels of crime, unemployment…" (NSW Government 2016, PDF p. 24), which section 4 tests.

3. Housing: the strategy, and the conflict between home and real estate

The plan has treated Waterloo both as people's homes and as a way to pay for new housing. In December 2015 the state announced that the estate would be demolished and rebuilt with about 30 per cent social and 70 per cent private housing, the sale of the private dwellings funding the project (Zanardo et al. 2024, 1208). The planning proposal says the existing properties are "at the end of their economic life" (LAHC 2020, 23), yet the same study gives their average age as 44 years against a benchmark life of 60 (Turner Studio & Turf 2020, Part 1, PDF p. 6). Madden and Marcuse (2016) call this tension a conflict between home and real estate: housing as lived, social space against housing as an instrument for profit-making.

The promises to tenants grew after 2023, but the planning rules were written before them (Figure 2). The plan approved in 2022 provides 3,012 dwellings, of which 847 are social housing, and its controls date from November 2022 (NSW Department of Planning and Environment 2022, PDF p. 37). After a change of government in March 2023, the share of social and affordable housing across the estate was raised from 34 to 50 per cent, tenants were promised the right to return, and relocation was to proceed in small stages (NSW Government 2023); in 2024 at least six months' notice and dedicated support were added (NSW Government 2024). The 2026 concept application proposes at least 30 per cent of residential floor area as social housing and no more than 50 per cent as market housing (NSW Department of Planning, Housing and Infrastructure 2026), and none of the planning documents for this stage mentions a right of return.

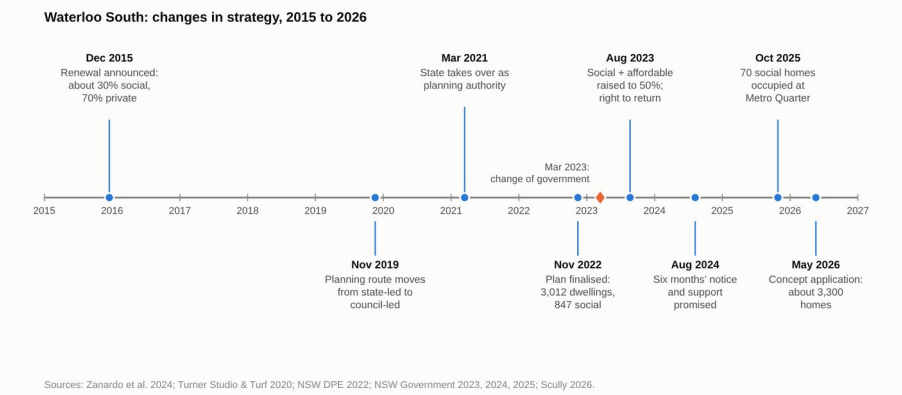


Figure 2. The strategy for Waterloo South changed several times between 2015 and 2026.

The strategy can be sorted into measures that protect the money and measures that protect the tenants' homes. On the money side, the planning proposal says that the existing planning rules "would not be capable of supporting a feasible redevelopment of the entire site given the costs of demolition and construction" (LAHC 2020, 92), and the sale of private dwellings carries the cost. On the tenants' side are the right to return and more social homes in Waterloo South than there are now (Homes NSW 2026a). No official document sorts the strategy in this way. Sections 4 and 5 ask which side the binding rules protect.

4. Segregation: testing the remedy against the chain

The state's case for renewal rests on an argument that segregation research also makes: disadvantage that clusters in one place reproduces itself. Tammaru et al. (2021) describe vicious circles of segregation as the product of connected social and spatial inequalities in different life domains: advantage breeds advantage and disadvantage breeds disadvantage. Five steps can be distinguished (Figure 3): disadvantage clusters spatially, neighbourhood effects follow, poor perceptions shape who moves, segregation spreads to other domains such as schools and work, and it becomes immobility across the life course and across generations (Rosengren 2026). Future Directions follows the same chain: it finds disadvantage concentrated in estates and proposes mixed tenure as the remedy (NSW Government 2016, PDF pp. 9, 24).

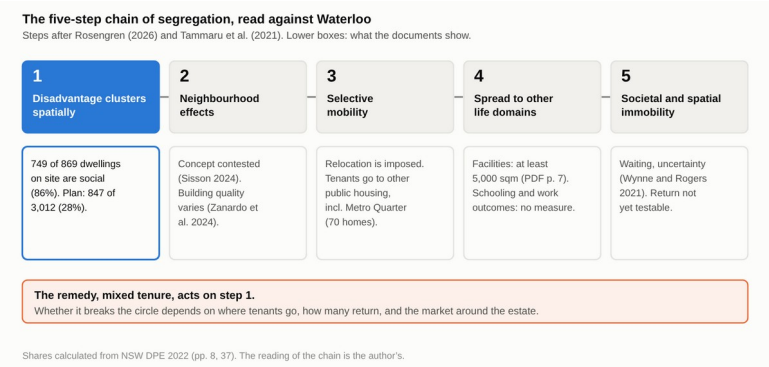


Figure 3. The five-step chain of segregation, read against Waterloo: mixed tenure acts on step 1.

On step 1 the plan works: social housing falls from 86 per cent of the site's dwellings to 28 per cent. Waterloo South now has 749 social and 120 private dwellings, and the plan approved in 2022 has 847 social dwellings among 3,012 (NSW Department of Planning and Environment 2022, PDF pp. 8, 37; shares calculated from these figures; Figure 4). Homes

NSW now gives about 1,050 social homes among about 3,300 (Homes NSW 2026a), about 32 per cent. This is dilution by social mixing, which makes concentrated disadvantage less visible. The same plan can also be described as growth, 749 social dwellings becoming about 1,050, so a document can call it dilution or growth depending on whether it counts share or number.

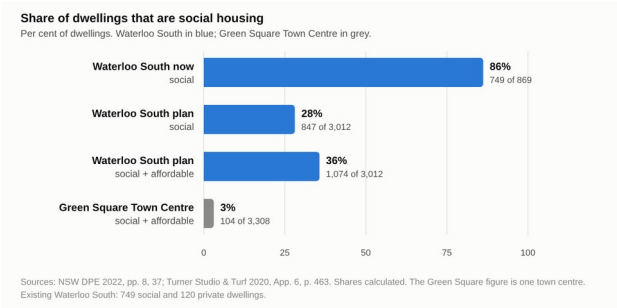


Figure 4. The share of social housing at Waterloo South falls from about 86 to about 28 per cent in the plan; Green Square Town Centre is shown for comparison.

Who lives on the site shapes what step 1 dilutes. In February 2026, 607 tenant households with 836 residents remained on Waterloo South: 77 per cent were single-person households, 62 per cent had a tenant over 55 (or over 45 for Aboriginal tenants), and 19 per cent of tenants were Aboriginal (Homes NSW 2026b, PDF p. 7). In September 2019 their households had an average income of $525 a week, 73 per cent lived alone and 33 per cent drew their main income from a disability pension (GHD 2020, PDF pp. 30, 34). The poverty line for a single adult in 2019–20 was $489 a week (Davidson, Bradbury and Wong 2023, PDF p. 8), so the average household was near it. Its neighbourhoods ranked in the two lowest deciles of disadvantage in the state (GHD 2020, PDF p. 30). The concentration is therefore one of low income, age, disability and living alone. Steps 4 and 5 of the chain concern schools, work and the next generation, and 149 of the 995 tenants in July 2025 were under 18 (Homes NSW 2025a, PDF p. 19).

The area around the estate has already been mixed by the market. The social baseline report says that the surroundings “have undergone significant redevelopment in recent years”, which “changed local demographics, with more tertiary students, … professionals, young families, couples without children” (GHD 2020, PDF p. 3). Ten of the 15 neighbourhood units of Waterloo East rank in the top three deciles of advantage, though three rank in the lowest, and the suburb as a whole ranks in the second decile (PDF pp. 37, 75).

The chain also runs at the scale of the whole city, and the remedy acts on the estate. In Greater Sydney the large social-housing estates that dominate a disadvantaged suburb lie mainly in the western suburbs: of 177 disadvantaged suburbs in Sydney, Melbourne and Brisbane, 14 are dominated by social housing and 13 of those are in Sydney (Hulse et al. 2014, PDF pp. 16, 40). The same study had to set aside Waterloo and Haymarket as statistical outliers, Waterloo for “rapid gentrification” (PDF p. 38). The latest metropolitan study finds Sydney’s segregation rising because very-high-income households cluster in the least disadvantaged areas “rather than” because very-low-income households cluster (Sarkar et al. 2024, PDF p. 34). The state’s metropolitan plan lists “areas of high social housing concentration where there is good access to services, transport and jobs” as candidates for

renewal (Greater Sydney Commission 2018, PDF p. 61), which points renewal at well-served locations such as Waterloo's. Renewing Waterloo can therefore reduce concentration on the estate without changing the metropolitan pattern.

The 70:30 ratio was not designed from evidence about what mixing achieves. Khor et al. (2023, 77), citing Darcy and Rogers (2019), trace it to Bonnyrigg, a suburban estate, where social-mixing outcomes "was not a determinant of decision-making", which fits the financialisation of housing (Aalbers 2016): the rules enforce a quantity of tenure, not an outcome.

The planning rules guarantee how much social housing is built, but not who lives in it and not whether tenants can come back. The site-specific controls that the plan finalisation report lists for Waterloo South require no less than 26.5 per cent of residential floor area as social housing, no less than 7.0 per cent as affordable housing, and at least 5,000 square metres for community, health and childcare facilities (NSW Department of Planning and Environment 2022, PDF p. 7). Such minimums fix which kinds of housing the new buildings contain, not which households hold them. The Design Guide, where the tenure and Aboriginal housing provisions sit, is only to be considered in development applications "but not to elevate the guidance within the design guide to development standards" (PDF p. 7).

Return and relocation appear as guidance and statements, not as planning controls. The final planning proposal records that the Land and Housing Corporation "has noted" that current residents have a right of return (Hassell 2022a, PDF p. 59), and the department accepted a response that "appropriate relocation strategies will be developed" (NSW Department of Planning and Environment 2022, PDF p. 14). Neither document requires anyone to track what happens to tenants after they move. The strategy has since been written down in Homes NSW's support guide of February 2026, which gives existing tenants a right to return that "will be an individual choice for each tenant" (Homes NSW 2026b, PDF p. 16). The guide is not a planning control and sets no deadline for return. The rules reach step 1; steps 3 and 5 depend on guidance and promises (Table 1).

Table 1. The measures protecting Waterloo South tenants and housing, sorted by where they sit in the planning documents read (2022 versions, with the 2025–26 additions).

Measure	Where it sits	Source
Social housing: no less than 26.5% of residential floor area	Binding site-specific control	DPE 2022, PDF p. 7
Affordable housing: no less than 7.0% of residential floor area	Binding site-specific control	DPE 2022, PDF p. 7
Affordable housing in perpetuity; a socially diverse population; Aboriginal housing provisions	Design Guide (to be considered, not a development standard)	Hassell 2022b, PDF p. 22; DPE 2022, PDF p. 7
Right of return	Statement in the planning record ("has noted"), and announcements	Hassell 2022a, PDF p. 59; NSW Government 2023, 2024
Relocation strategy	Statement ("will be developed")	DPE 2022, PDF p. 14
Six months' notice; up to two offers; return as an individual choice for existing tenants; check-ins after a move	Guidance document of Homes NSW, outside the planning controls	Homes NSW 2026b, PDF pp. 14, 16
Floor-area shares in the 2026 concept: social at least 30%, market	Proposed in the concept application (on exhibition May–June 2026)	DPHI 2026

at most 50%, the rest affordable		

Steps 2 to 5 are where the evidence is thinnest. Sisson (2024) notes that the concept of neighbourhood effects behind "concentrated disadvantage" "controversially" places the cause in the estate. Reviews offer limited evidence on steps 2 to 5: a systematic review of 27 UK studies found some positive effects of mixed tenure in the social and residential domains but none on social capital (Sautkina, Bond and Kearns 2012), and Manley, van Ham and Doherty (2011) conclude that the evidence base for social mixing is "far from robust". No document measures residents' mobility or opportunities.

Taken together, these facts change what step 1 achieves. The estate is a pocket of low-income, older and disabled households inside a neighbourhood the market has already mixed, so the mix cannot be the measure of success. What the residents stand to keep or lose is their place, and the test is whether the households now there remain, which section 5 takes up through four forms of displacement.

5. Gentrification: price, cost and promise

The renewal is a case of state-led, new-build gentrification. Davidson and Lees (2005, 1170) give four defining elements: reinvestment of capital, social upgrading of the locale by incoming high-income groups, landscape change, and direct or indirect displacement of low-income groups. The first three are present at Waterloo. The sale of private dwellings reinvests capital in public land and closes Smith's (1979) rent gap, between potential and actual ground rent, through the state itself; the landlord's consultants expect the renewal to attract "a similar demographic" to Waterloo East (GHD 2020, PDF p. 31); and the buildings are replaced. The fourth is the question of this section. Hackworth and Smith (2001, 468–469) describe a third wave in which the state is "more involved in the process" and large developers orchestrate reinvestment. No published author places Waterloo on a named stage, so this placement is the paper's own, and it rests on the features listed.

Mixing is the policy that this remedy shares with "positive gentrification", and the evidence for it is weak. Lees (2008) finds a "poor evidence base" for that policy, which is promoted in the belief that it will reduce segregation. Yrjänä (2026) shows in Helsinki how an anti-segregation policy can serve state-led gentrification, and Hochstenbach (2017) finds for Amsterdam that the instruments of social mixing moved to high-demand neighbourhoods, the direction that Shrestha, Ruming and Rogers (2025) trace in Sydney. Davidson (2008, 2402) puts the question that mixing leaves open: "how many people should be displaced—lose their home and neighbourhood—before it becomes a problem?" There are two routes to better conditions for the people on the estate: upgrade the buildings for them where they are, or sell part of the land to richer residents to pay for new ones. The documents take the second. The market share, which pays for the rest, fell from 66.5 per cent of residential floor area in the 2022 proposal to at most 50 per cent in the 2026 concept (Hassell 2022a, PDF p. 19; NSW Department of Planning, Housing and Infrastructure 2026).

Marcuse (1985, 205–208) separates four forms of displacement and says that all four must be counted. The rest of this section asks what evidence from 2019 to 2026 exists for each at Waterloo South (Table 2). Direct displacement is the landlord moving its own tenants, and

here the process is well documented. Notices went to 145 Stage 1 tenants in February 2025 (Homes NSW 2025c, PDF p. 2), and about 60 had been relocated by November 2025, “either to a home in the local area or to another area of their choice in NSW” (Homes NSW 2025b, PDF p. 3). Tenants receive at least six months’ notice and up to two offers, may ask to move to a different part of Sydney or NSW, can appeal an offer first within Homes NSW and then to the independent Housing Appeals Committee, and are visited about three and six months after moving (Homes NSW 2026b, PDF pp. 14, 16). Two local destinations are named, 70 social homes at the Metro Quarter and about 95 at Elizabeth Street, Redfern (Homes NSW 2026a), and in May 2026 the ABC reported that at least 70 tenants had moved into the homes beside the metro station (Bowring 2026). In 2020 the landlord’s consultants had listed, among features the relocation approach “could include”, that “the majority of residents will be provided alternative dwellings on site during the construction phase” (Elton Consulting 2020, PDF p. 88); the documents of 2025 and 2026 speak instead of the local area or an area of the tenant’s choice. The process is also disputed: activists said that at least ten people were still living in the fenced block, and the minister said the remaining people were not tenants (Bowring 2026).

What the evidence does not show is the outcome. No document counts how many tenants went to each destination, and none can yet count returns, because return is possible only once the new buildings are finished and is “an individual choice for each tenant” (Homes NSW 2026b, PDF p. 16). Where return has been counted elsewhere it has been low: about 40 per cent of residents came back to Carlton in Melbourne and 20 per cent to Kensington (Porter et al. 2023, 30), fewer than 11 per cent of the 16,846 relocated family households in Chicago lived in the new mixed-income developments at the end of 2010 (Joseph and Chaskin 2012, 378), and the average at four HOPE VI sites was 5 per cent (Comey 2007, cited in Joseph and Chaskin 2012, 379). Goetz (2010) ties low return to the years between displacement and completion. Not returning is not always a loss. Popkin et al. (2004, 29) note that it “does not automatically mean that residents are worse off”, and in a 2023 survey of about 300 Waterloo tenants 45 per cent agreed that, given the opportunity, they would move out of the neighbourhood, against 35 per cent who disagreed (Meikle et al. 2024, PDF p. 15). A return rate at Waterloo would therefore have to be read beside where tenants went and whether they chose it, and neither is recorded.

Chain displacement counts households that leave before the last resident is moved. Relocation began in February 2025 and runs in phases over 10 to 15 years, and the high-rise buildings of Waterloo North and Central are to stay for at least another ten (Homes NSW 2026c, PDF p. 2), so the estate empties slowly. The count was 995 tenants in July 2025 (Homes NSW 2025a, PDF p. 19) and 836 residents in 607 households in February 2026 (Homes NSW 2026b, PDF p. 7), but the two figures carry different labels, and no document says how many tenants left before they were notified. In 2020 the landlord’s consultants listed “anxiety associated with relocation” and “current inability to age in place” among the issues of older residents (Elton Consulting 2020, PDF p. 77), and Wynne and Rogers (2021) argue that the threat of eviction “has already done significant damage to their relationship to place” before any move. These describe a pressure to leave early; they do not count who did. The evidence for this form is thin.

Exclusionary displacement keeps similar households from moving in, and it is where the evidence of protection is strongest. The number of social homes rises from 749 to about 1,050 (Homes NSW 2026a). At least 7 per cent of residential floor area is to be affordable housing held in perpetuity by a community housing provider, other affordable housing is to be kept for at least 25 years, affordable homes are to go to "a mix of households on very low to moderate incomes" at "no more than 30% of gross household income", and 20 per cent of the social housing floor area is to be prioritised for First Nations tenants, all of which the applicant expects to be imposed as consent conditions (Beam Planning 2026, App. E, PDF p. 6). A rising number is unusual. Bonnyrigg lost about 200 social dwellings (Porter et al. 2023, 30), and on 50 London estates the number of homes almost doubled while some 8,000 social rented homes were lost (London Assembly Housing Committee 2015, 3). The share of social housing nonetheless falls from 86 to about 32 per cent, and the documents examined do not say how the additional homes will be allocated.

Displacement pressure is the strain of watching the neighbourhood change around you. The area around the estate has already been rebuilt (section 4), the suburb's median household income rose about 35 per cent between 2016 and 2021 (GHD 2020, PDF p. 35; Australian Bureau of Statistics 2021), and the landlord's consultants expect the renewal to attract "a similar demographic" to Waterloo East (GHD 2020, PDF p. 31). Hulse et al. (2014, PDF p. 38) name Waterloo an outlier for "rapid gentrification", and Atkinson et al. (2011, PDF p. 10) found that in gentrified parts of Sydney and Melbourne public renters moved out at a higher rate than expected, a change they link to "estate remodelling and demolitions". Davidson (2008, 2391–2392) adds that social housing tenants "may be insulated from some indirect displacement pressures" but not from changes in community and neighbourhood services. In a 2023 survey 58 per cent of tenants said they felt part of their community (Meikle et al. 2024, PDF p. 15), which is what community and neighbourhood-resource displacement would wear away. These show that the area has changed. None measures what the change did to tenants, and none of the planning documents examined addresses it.

Table 2. Evidence from 2019 to 2026 for each of Marcuse's four forms of displacement at Waterloo South.

Form of displacement	Strength of evidence	What the evidence shows and cannot show	Source
Direct displacement (the landlord moves its tenants)	Process documented; outcome absent	145 Stage 1 tenants notified (February 2025); about 60 relocated by November 2025; six months' notice, two offers, appeal, visits after the move; named destinations at the Metro Quarter and Elizabeth Street. No count by destination; return is an individual choice and cannot yet occur. Elsewhere 5 to about 40 per cent returned.	Homes NSW 2025b, 2025c, 2026a–c; Bowring 2026; Porter et al. 2023
Chain displacement (households leave before the last resident)	Thin	Phases over 10 to 15 years from February 2025; 995 tenants (July 2025) and 836 residents in 607 households (February 2026) carry different labels; consultants and researchers describe anxiety before any move; no count of early leavers.	Homes NSW 2025a, 2026b, 2026c; Elton 2020; Wynne and Rogers 2021
Exclusionary displacement (similar households kept out)	Strongest, with gaps	Social homes 749 to about 1,050; at least 7 per cent affordable in perpetuity, the rest for 25 years; 20 per cent of social floor area prioritised for First Nations tenants; share falls from 86 to about 32 per cent; allocation rules not found.	Homes NSW 2026a; Beam Planning 2026, App. E

Displacement pressure (the neighbourhood changes around tenants)	Area change shown; effect on tenants not measured	Waterloo East rebuilt; suburb median household income up about 35 per cent, 2016 to 2021; consultants expect a similar demographic; 58 per cent of surveyed tenants feel part of the community; no tenant-level measure of change.	GHD 2020; ABS 2021; Hulse et al. 2014; Atkinson et al. 2011; Meikle et al. 2024

Marcuse (1984–85, 933–934) observes that the costs and benefits of gentrification fall on different classes, and that public resources invested in a neighbourhood "will not help existing lower-income residents without specific provisions designed to achieve that end". At Waterloo the cost of the move falls on low-income tenants, and the benefits go to the buyers of the new flats, to the state that sells the land, and to the further social homes that the sales pay for. Freeman (2005) finds that gentrifying neighbourhoods in New York could change without much displacement, but his data do not isolate a landlord relocating its own tenants for a rebuild. Counting the four forms, the evidence shows protection of the number of social homes and process without outcome for the people now living there. The question is therefore not whether the new buildings will exist but whether the people who live there now will be among those who live in them, and the documents promise return without showing it.

6. Conclusion and discussion

The approved plan dilutes the estate, and the evidence from 2019 to 2026 protects the number of social homes better than the people who live there. Counting Marcuse's four forms of displacement, the evidence is strongest for exclusionary displacement, where the number of social homes rises from 749 to about 1,050. It records a process without an outcome for direct displacement, is thin for chain displacement, and describes the area but not the tenants for displacement pressure (Table 2). Return cannot yet be observed, and where it has been counted elsewhere between 5 and about 40 per cent of tenants came back. In a neighbourhood the market has already mixed, and in a metropolis where disadvantage lies elsewhere, adding richer neighbours does not by itself break the circle at Waterloo. Whether it is broken or only moved is decided by who is still there when the buildings are finished, and the evidence available in 2026 cannot say.

This paper adds three small things to existing work on Waterloo. First, it reads the renewal as state-led, new-build gentrification and collects the evidence for each of Marcuse's four forms of displacement (Table 2). Four studies of Waterloo (Zanardo et al. 2024; Sisson 2024; Wynne and Rogers 2021; Sisson and Ruming 2025) deal with reputation, land value, displacement and housing supply, and none uses the vocabulary of segregation or sorts the evidence by all four forms. Second, it sorts each protection for tenants by where it sits (Table 1) and finds that the rules guarantee floor area while return and relocation are guidance and statements. Third, it separates the share from the number of social homes, and sets the estate against its neighbourhood and against the Sydney-wide pattern of disadvantage.

The case supports some frameworks and limits others. It is consistent with the view of Stein and Davidson that the state plans and justifies large-scale redevelopment (Davidson 2018, 249), and it extends the global-city account: the pressure reached Waterloo through a metro station, not through the corridor strategy. It limits two accounts. In Yrjänä's (2026) Helsinki the state pays a subsidy gap to de-risk private investment, while in the Waterloo documents

the money runs the other way, with private sales paying for social homes. And accounts that set home against real estate (Madden and Marcuse 2016) treat the two sides as opposed, while Waterloo's policy kept changing, raising the social and affordable share from 34 to 50 per cent in 2023 (NSW Government 2023).

This argument has limits. It rests on documents and published studies, not on interviews, so residents' experience comes through other researchers and single news reports. Return cannot yet be observed, because the first new buildings are not finished, so the paper collects evidence on safeguards and process and not on outcomes. The body of the environmental impact statement, the social impact assessment, the gazetted rules and the Homes NSW relocation policy beyond its guides were not read (of the impact statement only appendices A to E were), so "not among the rules" means only that a measure is not in the documents examined. Shrestha, Ruming and Rogers (2025) and Hochstenbach (2017) are known here from their abstracts. Destinations are named but not counted, and the figures on return come from other cities, where tenure, programme and period differ. The five-step chain and Marcuse's four forms are frames applied to the documents, not terms the documents use. The placement of Waterloo as late-stage, state-led, new-build gentrification is the paper's own. The conclusion therefore holds for the documents examined and may change when the exhibited proposal is read in full.

Planning could do for people what it already does for floor space. The rules fix floor space by tenure; they could also require reporting on how many tenants return, when, and to the same place or only the same area, and where those who do not return live. The share of social housing should be published beside the number of social homes, and the rules for allocating the additional homes should be published. The permanence of the affordable homes beyond the first 7 per cent, which the applicant says will be held in perpetuity, should be confirmed. Where the existing buildings can be renovated, retention should be considered (Zanardo et al. 2024). It asks that the cost of the remedy to the people it is meant to help be counted.

References

Aalbers, M. B. 2016. *The Financialization of Housing: A Political Economy Approach*. Routledge.

Atkinson, R., M. Wulff, M. Reynolds, and A. Spinney. 2011. *Gentrification and Displacement: The Household Impacts of Neighbourhood Change*. AHURI Final Report No. 160. Australian Housing and Urban Research Institute.

Australian Bureau of Statistics. 2021. "Waterloo (Suburb): 2021 Census QuickStats." https://abs.gov.au/census/find-census-data/quickstats/2021/SAL14201.

Australian Bureau of Statistics. 2026. "Total Value of Dwellings, June Quarter 2026." Released September 8, 2026. https://www.abs.gov.au/statistics/economy/price-indexes-and-inflation/total-value-dwellings/latest-release.

Beam Planning. 2026. *Environmental Impact Statement, Waterloo Estate (South) Concept SSDA, SSD-93222706: Appendices A–E (SEARs Compliance Table, Statutory Compliance Table, Mitigation Measures, Community Consultation Table, Design Guide Assessment)*. April 2026.

Bowring, D. 2026. "Housing Minister Says Waterloo Community ‘Not Functional’ as Demolition Looms for Public Housing Estate." *ABC News*, May 25, 2026. https://www.abc.net.au/news/2026-05-25/waterloo-public-housing-estate-fenced-off-ahead-of-demolition/106718016.

Chatterjee, P., A. Sisson, J. Condie, and L. Wynne. 2018. "We Still Live Here: Public Housing Tenants Fight for Their Place in the City." *The Conversation*, November 19, 2018. https://theconversation.com/we-still-live-here-public-housing-tenants-fight-for-their-place-in-the-city-107188.

Davidson, M. 2018. "New-Build Gentrification." In *Handbook of Gentrification Studies*, edited by L. Lees with M. Phillips, chap. 15, beginning p. 247. Edward Elgar.

Freeman, L. 2005. "Displacement or Succession? Residential Mobility in Gentrifying Neighborhoods." *Urban Affairs Review* 40 (4): 463–491.

Elton Consulting. 2020. *Waterloo South Social Sustainability Report*. Prepared for NSW Land and Housing Corporation. September 4, 2020. https://www.cityofsydney.nsw.gov.au/-/media/corporate/files/projects/policy-planning-changes/planning-proposal-request-waterloo-estate-south/attachment-12---social-sustainability-study---waterloo-south-updated-version-september-2020.pdf.

GHD. 2020. *Social Baseline Report – Waterloo*. Prepared for NSW Land and Housing Corporation. March 2020. https://www.cityofsydney.nsw.gov.au/-/media/corporate/files/projects/policy-planning-changes/planning-proposal-request-waterloo-estate-south/social-baseline-study-waterloo-south.pdf.

Goetz, E. 2010. Testimony before the U.S. House Committee on Financial Services, Subcommittee on Housing and Community Opportunity, on the Choice Neighborhoods Initiative, March 17, 2010. https://financialservices.house.gov/media/file/hearings/111/goetz_march_2010_testimony.pdf.

Greater Sydney Commission. 2018. *Greater Sydney Region Plan: A Metropolis of Three Cities*. https://www.planning.nsw.gov.au/sites/default/files/2024-04/greater-sydney-region-plan.pdf.

Davidson, M. 2008. "Spoiled Mixture: Where Does State-Led 'Positive' Gentrification End?" *Urban Studies* 45 (12): 2385–2405.

Davidson, M., and L. Lees. 2005. "New-Build 'Gentrification' and London's Riverside Renaissance." *Environment and Planning A* 37 (7): 1165–1190.

Davidson, P., B. Bradbury, and M. Wong. 2023. *Poverty in Australia 2023: Who Is Affected*. Australian Council of Social Service and UNSW Sydney. https://www.acoss.org.au/.

Hassell. 2022a. *Planning Proposal: Waterloo Estate (South)*. Final version, Attachment A to NSW Department of Planning and Environment (2022).

Hassell. 2022b. *Waterloo Estate (South): Design Guide 2022*. November 2022. Attachment B, City of Sydney Council meeting papers. https://meetings.cityofsydney.nsw.gov.au/documents/s70608/.

Hackworth, J., and N. Smith. 2001. "The Changing State of Gentrification." *Tijdschrift voor Economische en Sociale Geografie* 92 (4): 464–477.

Hochstenbach, C. 2017. "State-Led Gentrification and the Changing Geography of Market-Oriented Housing Policies." *Housing, Theory and Society* 34 (4): 399–419. https://doi.org/10.1080/14036096.2016.1271825.

Joseph, M. L., and R. J. Chaskin. 2012. "Mixed-Income Developments and Low Rates of Return: Insights from Relocated Public Housing Residents in Chicago." *Housing Policy Debate* 22 (3): 377–405. https://doi.org/10.1080/10511482.2012.680479.

Hulse, K., H. Pawson, M. Reynolds, and S. Herath. 2014. *Disadvantaged Places in Urban Australia: Analysing Socio-Economic Diversity and Housing Market Performance*. AHURI Final Report No. 225. Australian Housing and Urban Research Institute.

Homes NSW. 2025a. *Waterloo South People and Place Plan 2025*. October 2025. https://www.nsw.gov.au/sites/default/files/noindex/2025-10/waterloo-south-people-and-place-plan-2025.pdf.

Homes NSW. 2025c. "Waterloo Connect." Newsletter, May 2025. https://www.nsw.gov.au/sites/default/files/noindex/2025-06/waterloo-connect-newsletter-may-2025-english.pdf.

Homes NSW. 2025b. "Waterloo Connect." Newsletter, November 2025. https://www.nsw.gov.au/sites/default/files/noindex/2025-11/waterloo-newsletter-november-2025-in-english.pdf.

Homes NSW. 2026a. "Waterloo Renewal Project." Last updated October 21, 2026. https://www.nsw.gov.au/departments-and-agencies/homes-nsw/waterloo-renewal-project.

Homes NSW. 2026b. *Waterloo South Relocation and Support Guide*. February 2026. https://www.nsw.gov.au/sites/default/files/noindex/2026-03/waterloo-relocation-support-guide-feb-2026.pdf.

Homes NSW. 2026c. *Waterloo South Relocations: Frequently Asked Questions*. March 2026. https://www.nsw.gov.au/sites/default/files/noindex/2026-03/waterloo-relocations-faq-march-2026.pdf.

Khor, L.-A., L. Taylor, S. Glackin, S. Rowley, S. Siebel, D. Tinios, and R. Azizi. 2023. *From Mixed Tenure Development to Mixed Tenure Neighbourhoods*. AHURI Final Report No. 412. Australian Housing and Urban Research Institute. https://doi.org/10.18408/ahuri5229701.

London Assembly Housing Committee. 2015. *Knock It Down or Do It Up? The Challenge of Estate Regeneration*. Greater London Authority, February 2015.

Lees, L. 2008. "Gentrification and Social Mixing: Towards an Inclusive Urban Renaissance?" *Urban Studies* 45 (12): 2449–2470.

Madden, D., and P. Marcuse. 2016. *In Defense of Housing*. Verso.

Manley, D., M. van Ham, and J. Doherty. 2011. "Social Mixing as a Cure for Negative Neighbourhood Effects: Evidence Based Policy or Urban Myth?" IZA Discussion Paper No. 5634. https://econpapers.repec.org/RePEc:iza:izadps:dp5634.

Meikle, K., M. Williamson, C. O'Callaghan, F. Haigh, and M. Barr. 2024. "Social Housing in Waterloo: Tenant Perceptions of Safety, Health and Wellbeing, and the Community." Presentation, CPHCE Annual Forum, UNSW Sydney, September 2024. https://www.unsw.edu.au/content/dam/pdfs/medicine-health/cphce/events/2024-09-forum-presentation/2024-09-katherine-meikle-2024-annual-forum-presentation.pdf.

NSW Department of Planning and Environment. 2022. *Plan Finalisation Report: Waterloo Estate (South), PP-2021-3265*. https://shared-drupal-s3fs.s3.ap-southeast-2.amazonaws.com/master-test/fapub_pdf/Keelie+Drupal+Documents/Plan+Finalisation+Report.pdf.

NSW Department of Planning, Housing and Infrastructure. 2026. "Exhibition of State Significant Development Application and State Assessed Rezoning Proposal: Waterloo Estate (South) Concept, SSD-93222706." Public notice, May 6, 2026.

NSW Government. 2016. *Future Directions for Social Housing in NSW*. NSW Family and Community Services.

NSW Government. 2023. "Waterloo South Social and Affordable Housing Boosted to 50%." Media release, August 21, 2023. https://www.nsw.gov.au/media-releases/waterloo-affordable-housing-boost.

NSW Government. 2024. "Next Step Complete for Australia's Largest Social Housing Build." Media release, August 9, 2024. https://nsw.gov.au/media-releases/next-step-complete-for-australias-largest-social-housing-build.

NSW Land and Housing Corporation. 2020. *Waterloo South Planning Proposal Report*. Attachment B2. https://meetings.cityofsydney.nsw.gov.au/documents/s49951/.

NSW Planning and Environment. 2014. *A Plan for Growing Sydney: A Strong Global City, a Great Place to Live*. NSW Government.

Marcuse, P. 1984–85. "To Control Gentrification: Anti-Displacement Zoning and Planning for Stable Residential Districts." *N.Y.U. Review of Law and Social Change* 13: 931–952.

Marcuse, P. 1985. "Gentrification, Abandonment, and Displacement: Connections, Causes, and Policy Responses in New York City." *Washington University Journal of Urban and Contemporary Law* 28: 195–240.

Popkin, S. J., B. Katz, M. K. Cunningham, K. D. Brown, J. Gustafson, and M. A. Turner. 2004. *A Decade of HOPE VI: Research Findings and Policy Challenges*. Urban Institute and Brookings Institution.

Porter, L., L. Davies, K. Ruming, D. Kelly, D. Rogers, and K. Flanagan. 2023. *Understanding the Drivers and Outcomes of Public Housing Tenant Relocation*. AHURI Final Report No. 413. Australian Housing and Urban Research Institute. https://doi.org/10.18408/ahuri5328701.

Rosengren, K. 2026. "Segregation in a Retrenching Housing Regime." Lecture, Aalto University, January 27, 2026.

Sassen, S. 1991. *The Global City: New York, London, Tokyo*. Princeton University Press.

Sautkina, E., L. Bond, and A. Kearns. 2012. "Mixed Evidence on Mixed Tenure Effects: Findings from a Systematic Review of UK Studies, 1995–2009." *Housing Studies* 27 (6): 748–782. https://doi.org/10.1080/02673037.2012.714461.

Sarkar, S., R. Shrivastava, N. Gurran, and K. Chapple. 2024. *Spatial Segregation and Neighbourhood Change*. AHURI Final Report No. 414. Australian Housing and Urban Research Institute. https://doi.org/10.18408/ahuri7323601.

Shrestha, P., K. Ruming, and D. Rogers. 2025. "Dispersing the Public Housing 'Estate': Evolution of Public Housing Estate Renewal Projects in Sydney, NSW." *International Journal of Housing Policy*. Advance online publication, December 29, 2025. https://doi.org/10.1080/19491247.2025.2599101.

Sisson, A. 2024. "Public Housing and Territorial Stigma: Towards a Symbolic and Political Economy." *Housing Studies* 39 (5): 1199–1218. https://doi.org/10.1080/02673037.2022.2108383.

Sisson, A., and K. Ruming. 2025. "Calculating the System-Wide Supply Impacts of Social Housing Estate Renewal: New Measures and Methods." *Housing Studies* 40 (8): 1821–1845. https://doi.org/10.1080/02673037.2024.2378852.

Smith, N. 1979. "Toward a Theory of Gentrification: A Back to the City Movement by Capital, Not People." *Journal of the American Planning Association* 45 (4): 538–548.

Stein, S. 2019. *Capital City: Gentrification and the Real Estate State*. Verso.

Tammaru, T., D. Knapp, S. Silm, M. van Ham, and F. Witlox. 2021. "Spatial Underpinnings of Social Inequalities: A Vicious Circles of Segregation Approach." *Social Inclusion* 9 (2): 65–76. https://doi.org/10.17645/si.v9i2.4345.

Turner Studio & Turf. 2020. *Waterloo Estate – Waterloo South: Urban Design & Public Domain Study*. Part 1 and Appendix 6 case studies; planning proposal Attachment 5. City of Sydney meeting papers, Attachments B7a and B7i.

Wynne, L., and D. Rogers. 2021. "Emplaced Displacement and Public Housing Redevelopment: From Physical Displacement to Social, Cultural, and Economic Replacement." *Housing Policy Debate* 31 (3–5): 395–410. https://doi.org/10.1080/10511482.2020.1772337.

Yrjänä, H. 2026. "By Any Means Necessary: The Anti-Segregation Efforts and State-Led Gentrification in Helsinki." *Cities* 170: 106718. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.cities.2025.106718.

Zanardo, M., A. Sisson, C. Logan, and R. McLaughlan. 2024. "Wilful Ignorance at Waterloo: Public Housing Quality and Political Stigma in Sydney's Largest Estate Renewal." *Planning Perspectives* 39 (6): 1207–1239. https://doi.org/10.1080/02665433.2024.2337268.